

Ahlan — Complete Cost Book

Every price, where it goes, measured scenarios & monthly projections

Measured from live production traces — 5 Aug 2026 · FX: 1 USD = 49 EGP

1 · The price sheet — every rate we pay, and to whom

These are the only external costs in the system. Everything else (routing, pricing, bills, automations) is code and costs nothing per use.

What	Provider & model	Rate	Used for
Chat brain (default)	OpenAI gpt-4.1-mini	\$0.40 in / \$1.60 out per 1M tokens	Casual replies, order extraction, phrasing
Premium voice	OpenAI gpt-4.1	\$2.00 / \$8.00 per 1M	Angry guests, VIPs, first-timers (auto-escalate)
Router / choices	OpenAI gpt-4.1-nano	\$0.10 / \$0.40 per 1M	Message classification + option resolving
Voice notes	OpenAI 4o-mini-transcribe	\$0.003 per minute (per second billed)	VN -> text; A/B'd better than whisper-1
Photo understanding	OpenAI gpt-4o-mini vision	\$0.15 / \$0.60 per 1M	Guest sends a photo (complaints, menu asks)
WhatsApp messages	Meta	FREE inside 24h service window	ALL current traffic incl. automations
Template messages	Meta (future, needs approval)	~\$0.03–0.11 per message (Egypt)	Win-backs, reorder reminders — off today
Hosting	Railway (flows + api)	\$5–10 / month flat	The two backend services
Dashboard + DB	Vercel + Supabase	\$0 (free tiers, current scale)	Dashboard hosting, database, storage

Where money does NOT go: no per-order commission, no per-message WhatsApp fee in the 24h window, no per-seat license, no charge for fast-path replies, status pushes, courier pushes, or the recovery/upsell/review automations (all code).

2 · Cost per message type (measured, last 7 days of real traffic)

Message type	What happens inside	Cost (USD)	Cost (EGP)
Fast-path answer	Pure code: hours, location, price, price math, thanks, approved FAQs	\$0.0000	0.00
Router-only turn	nano classify + code dispatch	\$0.0001	0.005
Median chat/order turn	mini extraction + code + mini phrasing	\$0.0012	0.06
Average turn (all real traffic)	mix of the above	\$0.0031	0.15
Heavy chat turn (p90)	long context or premium-model escalation	\$0.0103	0.50
Voice-note add-on (7s)	transcription only, then normal turn	\$0.00035	0.017
Photo from guest	vision classify + reply	+\$0.0002	+0.01
Photo TO guest / menu PDF / receipt	sending media is free (in-window)	\$0.0000	0.00
Automation push	recovery / upsell / review — templated code	\$0.0000	0.00

3 · Real tested scenarios — ran today on production, costs from the traces

Each scenario below was actually executed through the live pipeline today. 'Turns' = guest messages. LLM cost is the trace-recorded total; VN cost added where voice was used.

Scenario (as tested)	Turns	Tokens in/out	LLM	+Voice	TOTAL EGP
"Total for 2 meals and a coke?" (price math)	1	0 / 0	0.000	-	0.00
Hours in Arabic / ingredients / thanks	1	0 / 0	0.000	-	0.00
"Send me a photo of the Iconic" (real image sent)	1	4.8k / 181	0.290	-	0.29
Delivery order, 3 turns, receipt PDF (O-C8GR)	3	5.7k / 312	0.242	-	0.24
Full VOICE order, 3 Arabic VNs (O-7J4F)	3	7.2k / 344	0.235	0.05	0.28
Smart-edit order: absorb+imply+add+remove (O-HBKT)	6	13.5k / 687	0.428	-	0.43
Classic pickup, options step by step (O-6P85)	7	15.9k / 686	0.445	-	0.45
Islam's real buggy VN session (6 VNs, repeats)	9	23.2k / 887	0.488	0.21	0.70
Menu question with PDF attached	1	4.8k / 192	0.501	-	0.50
Franco chit-chat (premium-voice escalation)	1	8.3k / 464	0.760	-	0.76
Injection attempt / bot-or-human / offers honesty	1	~4.5k / 190	~0.45	-	0.45

Read: a COMPLETE order costs 0.24–0.45 EGP. Single chit-chat questions that miss every fast path cost 0.29–0.76 EGP because they carry the menu + persona context; they are the optimization frontier (more approved FAQs in Settings push them to 0.00). The buggy Islam session shows why bugs cost money: 3 wasted turns = +0.2 EGP. Those bugs are fixed.

4 · Scenario walkthroughs — the story, then the math

A. Guest asks price then leaves

"bekam el loaded fries?" (Arabic) -> exact DB price. "shokran" -> closer.

- Turn 1: fast path (code) = 0.00
- Turn 2: closer (code) = 0.00

Total: 0.00 EGP

B. Classic text pickup order (5 turns)

Item -> options in one block -> answers -> payment -> confirm. Receipt PDF attached.

- 2 order turns @ ~0.06 = 0.12
- options/confirm turns partly code = 0.10
- receipt + PDF send = 0.00

Total: ~0.30 EGP

C. Full VOICE order — 3 Arabic voice notes (measured: O-7J4F)

One VN with everything -> pay VN -> confirm VN. New transcriber.

- 3 VNs x ~7s transcription = 0.05
- 3 LLM turns = 0.23

Total: 0.28 EGP

D. Voice order with accents + one garbled word

"diblo" (misspelled Diablo) fuzzy-matched by code (free); truly unclear word -> ONE nano resolver call.

- Same as C = 0.28
- resolver (nano, only when needed) = 0.005

Total: ~0.29 EGP

E. Guest sends a food photo + complaint

Vision reads the photo, bot empathizes, staff flagged if serious.

- vision = 0.01
- reply turn = 0.06-0.50 (mood-dependent)

Total: 0.07-0.51 EGP

F. Abandoned order recovered

Guest builds a draft, goes silent 45 min. Code push with buttons; guest taps Yes; order placed.

- recovery push = 0.00
- "yes" confirm turn = 0.06
- receipt = 0.00

Total: 0.06 EGP -> a recovered ORDER

G. Delivery day for one order

Order (3 turns) + courier auto-assigned + 4 driver-page pushes (on way / near / arrived / delivered) + review ask after 1h.

- order = 0.24
- assignment + 4 pushes + review ask = 0.00

Total: 0.24 EGP for the entire lifecycle

H. Browse-only guest

"eh el burgerat 3andoko?" (Arabic) -> burgers listed; "photo?" -> image; leaves.

- category ask = 0.43 (LLM lists w/ menu context)
- photo = 0.29

Total: ~0.72 EGP - the most expensive guest type; more FAQs => cheaper

5 · Predictions — per customer, per restaurant, weekly & monthly

Assumptions (conservative): average order = 5 guest turns; 30% of orders fully voice; every order accompanied by 1.5 browse/chat conversations at ~0.30 EGP each; automations free; FX 49.

Volume	Orders cost	Chat/browse cost	AI total /mo	Hosting	ALL-IN /mo	Per week
300 orders/mo	105 EGP	135 EGP	240 EGP	250-490 EGP	490-730 EGP	115-170
1,000 orders/mo	350 EGP	450 EGP	800 EGP	250-490 EGP	1,050-1,290	245-300
3,000 orders/mo	1,050 EGP	1,350 EGP	2,400 EGP	490 EGP	~2,890 EGP	~670
Per-customer view			Value			
One complete order conversation			0.24 - 0.45 EGP			
Typical customer / month (3 orders + 2 browses)			1.5 - 2.0 EGP			

Cost as % of a 300-EGP average ticket	~0.1 - 0.15%
1,000-order restaurant: AI cost per order all-in	~1.05 - 1.29 EGP

6 · Error margins & what could move these numbers

- Everything in section 3 is MEASURED, not estimated; sections 5's mix (turns/order, voice %, browse ratio) is the assumption layer — track it monthly from /api/metrics.
- Upside: every approved FAQ converts a paid chat turn to a free one forever; fast paths already answer common questions at 0.
- Downside risks: premium-voice escalations (angry guests) cost ~4x mini — capped by design to moods/VIPs; very long voice rambles (cap VNs at 60s is recommended); Meta template campaigns when enabled are a separate, per-send marketing budget.
- OpenAI price changes pass straight through; a model-tier switch (Settings -> AI) is one toggle.
- Multi-restaurant: each tenant pays only its own usage; hosting is shared — the marginal restaurant costs ONLY its AI usage (no new fixed cost until scale demands bigger instances).

7 · Revenue model — charging 1% per order

What Ahlan earns if the fee is 1% of each order's value. Anchors from the live Just Smash menu: cheapest realistic order (one sandwich) = 165 EGP -> 1.65 EGP fee; a single meal = 195-265 EGP -> ~2.00-2.65; measured average ticket ~300 EGP -> 3.00 per order.

Order type	Ticket (EGP)	1% fee	Our marginal cost	Margin per order
Minimum — one sandwich	165	1.65	~0.30-0.45	~1.2-1.35 (73-82%)
One meal	195-265	1.95-2.65	~0.30-0.45	~1.5-2.35 (77-83%)
Average ticket (measured)	~300	3.00	~0.35-0.55	~2.45-2.65 (82-88%)
Family order / bundle (4X4)	999-1,139	9.99-11.39	~0.45-0.70	~9.3-10.9 (93%+)

Monthly picture per restaurant (revenue = 1% fee, costs = section 5 all-in):

Volume	Revenue floor (all min orders)	Revenue expected (avg ticket)	All-in cost	PROFIT (expected)
300 orders/mo	495 EGP	900 EGP	490-730 EGP	+170 to +410 EGP
1,000 orders/mo	1,650 EGP	3,000 EGP	1,050-1,290 EGP	+1,710 to +1,950 EGP
3,000 orders/mo	4,950 EGP	9,000 EGP	~2,890 EGP	~+6,100 EGP
10 restaurants x 1,000	16,500 EGP	30,000 EGP	~11,000-13,000 EGP	~+17,000-19,000 EGP

Reading it: at 1% the fee on ONE average order (3 EGP) pays for ~7 orders' worth of AI. Break-even per restaurant is ~200-350 orders/month (where 1% covers the fixed hosting share); every order after that is ~82-88% margin. The floor row is the worst case where literally every order is a single cheapest sandwich. Voice orders reduce margin by only ~0.05 EGP each. Not included: Meta template campaigns (marketing, billed to the restaurant) and payment-gateway fees if online payment lands (typically borne by the restaurant's Paymob account).

8 · Productized pricing — the POS, the modules, and the road to \$1M

Everything below is ALREADY BUILT and running on the pilot. Anchors: Foodics/Simple Touch POS packages run ~800-2,500 EGP/mo in Egypt; WhatsApp-bot competitors charge \$8-129/mo for button-bots with no POS at all. Ahlan bundles a real AI waiter WITH the ops stack.

Module (all live today)	What the restaurant gets	Suggested price
Ahlan Chat — the AI waiter	WhatsApp ordering in Arabic/Franco/English + voice notes, menus/photos/receipts, CRM, automations (recovery, upsell, review ask)	999 EGP/mo + 1-3% per order
Ahlan POS	Full register: conversational entry, cashier PINs, discounts/tips/split, X/Z reports, stations, hold/fire, offline queue, Arabic RTL, kitchen board (KDS)	+750 EGP/mo
Delivery OS	Courier roster + smart auto-assignment, driver pages, live rider tracking, guest status pushes from the restaurant number	+500 EGP/mo
Campaigns	Win-back / reorder / birthday template blasts to the CRM (needs Meta approval)	1.5 EGP per sent message (our cost ~0.25-0.55)
Reviews & complaints	Ratings collected in-chat, bad ones flagged w/ handling workflow, Google-review funnel	+300 EGP/mo (build pending)
3D Sandwich Builder	Branded build-your-own page wired to orders + WhatsApp	+500 EGP/mo (build pending)
Extra branches	Per branch beyond 3 (multi-branch boards, branch PINs, per-branch codes)	+200 EGP/branch/mo
EVERYTHING bundle	All of the above, one bill	1,999 EGP/mo + 1.5% per order

What one restaurant is worth per month (1,000 orders, 300 EGP avg ticket):

Plan	Monthly revenue / restaurant	Our cost	Margin
Chat only @ 1%	999 + 3,000 = 3,999 EGP	~1,100 EGP	~72%
Chat + POS + Delivery @ 1%	2,249 + 3,000 = 5,249 EGP	~1,150 EGP	~78%
EVERYTHING @ 1.5%	1,999 + 4,500 = 6,499 EGP	~1,200 EGP	~81%
EVERYTHING @ 3%	1,999 + 9,000 = 10,999 EGP	~1,200 EGP	~89%
+ 1 campaign/mo (5k guests)	+7,500 EGP	~2,750 EGP	~63%

The \$1M/year map (4.08M EGP/month) — restaurants needed:

Model	Revenue / restaurant / mo	Restaurants for \$1M/yr	Reality check
1% commission only	3,000 EGP	~1,360	a grind — volume business
Chat plan @ 1%	3,999 EGP	~1,020	still heavy
Chat+POS+Delivery @ 1%	5,249 EGP	~780	possible at scale
EVERYTHING @ 1.5%	6,499 EGP	~630	credible 2-3yr target
EVERYTHING @ 3% + 1 campaign	~18,500 EGP	~220	<1% of Cairo's restaurants

Yearly gross profit — EVERYTHING bundle @ 1.5% (81% margin), 1,000 orders each:

Restaurants	Revenue / year	Gross profit / year	In USD
10	780k EGP	~636k EGP	~\$13k
50	3.9M EGP	~3.2M EGP	~\$65k
100	7.8M EGP	~6.3M EGP	~\$130k
300	23.4M EGP	~19M EGP	~\$388k
630	49M EGP (= \$1M revenue)	~40M EGP	~\$815k
1,000	78M EGP	~63M EGP	~\$1.29M PROFIT

Per restaurant: ~63,600 EGP gross profit/year (~\$1,300). Team asterisk: ~1 support person per 75 restaurants (15-20k EGP/mo) + sales — at 300 restaurants that's ~1M EGP/yr against 19M gross, so the margin survives a real payroll.

The honest conclusion: commission alone never gets there at 1%. The stack does — the POS, delivery OS and

campaigns you already built turn one restaurant from 3,000 EGP/mo into 6,500-18,500 EGP/mo, and the restaurant STILL pays 5-10x less than one aggregator. 220-630 restaurants is the whole company; greater Cairo alone has ~40-50k.

9 · What everyone else charges — and the suggested Ahlan price model

A. Aggregators (the money restaurants bleed today)

Player	Pricing	What 1,000 orders x 300 EGP costs the restaurant
Talabat (Egypt)	15-25% commission (up to 30% by tier) + one-time onboarding fee	45,000-75,000 EGP/month
Aggregators generally	15-30% incl. platform/payment fees	45,000-90,000 EGP/month

B. POS systems (ops only — no AI, no WhatsApp ordering)

Player	Pricing (Egypt)	Notes
Foodics Starter	1,506 EGP/mo	menu, reports, basic inventory
Foodics Basic	2,582 EGP/mo	+ more modules
Foodics Advanced	3,442 EGP/mo	full suite; hardware extra (\$300-800 one-time)
Simple Touch	quote-based; Egyptian cloud-POS norm is 1,500-3,500 EGP/mo	19 apps; Talabat hub; e-invoice

C. WhatsApp ordering / automation bots (chat only — button flows, no real AI, no POS)

Player	Pricing	Notes
OrderOnWhats	\$13-129/mo (640-6,300 EGP) + \$299-399 setup add-ons	chatbot + storefront, no POS
OlaClick	from \$8/mo (~400 EGP); free tier	digital menu + WhatsApp robot
Wati-class platforms	\$39-99/mo (1,900-4,900 EGP) + Meta conversation fees	generic WhatsApp automation, not restaurant-native
Deonde (white-label apps)	custom SaaS, typically \$50-200/mo	apps + delivery mgmt, no conversational AI

D. The stack, side by side — what you pay today vs Ahlan at a flat 5%

The restaurant's real monthly bill on 1,000 orders x 300 EGP (300,000 EGP of food):

Line item	Today's stack	With Ahlan (5% all-in)
Order channel	Talabat: 25% = 75,000 EGP	WhatsApp AI waiter: included
POS + kitchen board	Foodics Basic: 2,582 EGP	included
WhatsApp bot / storefront	OrderOnWhats-class: ~2,000 EGP	included (real AI, Arabic + voice)
Delivery management	aggregator-locked or manual	smart courier OS: included
Online card payments	Paymob: ~2.75% + 3 EGP/txn = ~8,700 EGP	still Paymob when used (~2.75%) - COD = 0
CRM & campaigns	locked inside Talabat — not yours	yours: full CRM + campaigns (1.5 EGP/msg)
Customer relationship	Talabat owns the guest	THE RESTAURANT owns the guest
MONTHLY TOTAL	~79,500-88,300 EGP (26-29% of revenue)	15,000 EGP flat (5%)
What stays in your pocket	-	+64,000-73,000 EGP EVERY MONTH

The one-liner: 'Talabat takes 25%. The POS takes 2,600. The bot takes 2,000. Paymob takes ~3%. We take 5% flat — and replace all of them except the card gateway. You keep the other 24%, and you keep YOUR customers.'

Ahlan's own economics at 5% flat (1,000-order restaurant):

	Value
Revenue: 5% x 300,000	15,000 EGP/mo per restaurant
Our cost (AI + share of hosting)	~1,200 EGP/mo
Gross margin	~92%
Restaurants for \$1M/yr	~272

Sensitivity: at 3% -> ~450 restaurants for \$1M; at 5% -> ~272; at 5% + one 5k-guest campaign/mo -> ~200. All still

under 1% of greater Cairo's restaurants. Caveat: 5% competes on the promise of replacing the aggregator's DIRECT-order share — Talabat still owns discovery of new customers; Ahlan owns the repeat relationship, which is where the volume is.

10 · Business levers, risks & the 3-year shape

Levers worth pulling

- ONE-TIME ONBOARDING FEE (2,500-5,000 EGP): menu import, options setup, staff training — Talabat charges one too; covers acquisition cost day one.
- ANNUAL PREPAY = 2 months free: cash upfront, churn locked; standard SaaS play.
- CAMPAIGN CREDITS: sell blocks (1,000 msgs = 1,250 EGP) — prepaid marketing wallet, ~65% margin.
- AGGREGATOR-MIGRATION PACKAGE: 'first month free if you put the WhatsApp number on your Talabat packaging' — their delivery bags become your acquisition channel.
- PARTNER CHANNEL: POS resellers / marketing agencies sell Ahlan for a 15-20% cut — Egypt restaurants buy from people they know.

Risks the model must survive

- FX: our costs are USD (OpenAI/Railway), revenue is EGP. A devaluation raises costs ~proportionally; the natural hedge is that menu prices (and thus commission) inflate too — the base fees should be reviewed each devaluation.
- Meta policy: template pricing or the 24h-window rules can change; automations are architected window-first so the free lane stays free.
- Churn: a restaurant leaving takes its % with it — the POS + CRM + campaigns lock-in is the defense (the data belongs to them, but the workflow lives here).
- Aggregator retaliation: Talabat could cut commissions for exclusives; the counter is owning the repeat-order relationship they can't see.

A plausible 3-year shape (EVERYTHING @ 1.5%, conservative ramp)

Year	Restaurants (avg)	Revenue	Gross profit	Team cost (est)	Net-ish
Y1 — prove it	25	1.95M EGP	1.6M EGP	~0.6M EGP	~1.0M EGP
Y2 — repeatable sales	120	9.4M EGP	7.6M EGP	~2.0M EGP	~5.6M EGP
Y3 — scale	350	27.3M EGP	22.1M EGP	~4.5M EGP	~17.6M EGP (~\$360k)

Y3 at 350 restaurants is still <1% of greater Cairo. Add the 5%-flat tier or campaigns and each column roughly doubles.

11 · Company running costs — domain, email, hosting, everything

A. Domain (Cloudflare Registrar sells at cost, zero markup — verify exact price at purchase)

Option	Price / year	Notes
ahlan.com / ahlaan.com	~\$10-11	cheapest, most trusted by restaurants; free WHOIS privacy + DNS
ahlan.ai	~\$70-110	registry fee is high everywhere; strong AI-brand signal
Both (.com redirects to .ai)	~\$85-120	common startup move: own the brand, pick one to serve

B. Email on that domain

Need	Tool	Cost
RECEIVE at info@ / support@ / adel@ (unlimited addresses !' your Gmail)	Cloudflare Email Routing	FREE
SEND as you@domain (1 user, custom domain, webmail)	Zoho Mail free plan	FREE
SEND with real Gmail + shared inboxes (when you hire)	Google Workspace	\$6 / user / month
App emails to guests (receipts, review asks)	Resend (3,000/mo free) or Brevo	FREE at our volume

Cloudflare cannot SEND mail — routing is receive-only. That is why a mailbox provider sits next to it. Set SPF/DKIM/DMARC on day one (one-click in Cloudflare) or your mail lands in spam.

C. Everything, at three stages

Line item	Pilot (1 resto)	10 restaurants	300 restaurants
Domain (.com, amortised)	\$0.90/mo	\$0.90/mo	\$0.90/mo
Email (routing + Zoho free !' Workspace)	\$0	~\$12 (2 seats)	~\$60 (10 seats)
Dashboard hosting (Cloudflare Pages)	\$0	\$0	\$0-5
Backend + bot (Railway Hobby \$5 + usage)	\$5-10	\$10-20	\$150-300
Supabase — project per restaurant	\$0 (free tier)	~\$125	~\$3,025
Supabase — ONE shared project instead	\$0	\$25	~\$200
OpenAI (LLM + voice notes)	\$5-16	~\$160	~\$4,800
WhatsApp / Meta (in-window replies)	\$0	\$0	\$0
TOTAL — project per restaurant	\$6-27/mo	~\$310/mo	~\$8,040/mo
TOTAL — shared database	\$6-27/mo	~\$210/mo	~\$5,265/mo

Read it: the whole company runs on roughly \$10-25/month until restaurant #2 forces Supabase Pro. Two lines dominate at every scale — OpenAI, and the choice of one-database-per-restaurant vs one shared. Nothing else ever exceeds a few hundred dollars.

Cheapest-good stack, decided

- Domain + DNS: Cloudflare Registrar (at cost)
- Dashboard: Cloudflare Pages — FREE and permits commercial use (Vercel's free tier does not, which would otherwise cost \$20/mo)
- Backend + bot: Railway Hobby \$5 plan forever — Pro buys only longer logs, team seats and 42 replicas, none of which are speed or capacity for us
- Database/auth/storage/realtime: Supabase (free !' Pro at restaurant #2)
- Email: Cloudflare Routing + Zoho free, upgrade to Workspace on the first hire
- Self-hosting on a VPS (Hetzner ~€4.50 for 2 vCPU/4 GB) is cheaper per unit of RAM, but you then own OS patching, SSL, deploys and monitoring — not worth founder time until Railway crosses ~\$50/month.